

FocusDesk

Research, product specification, design decisions and development evidence

One offline desktop app for planning tasks, focusing on them, and reviewing actual study time. The combined design brings the required to-do and Pomodoro/time-tracking tools into one application.

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Repository github.com/YukiJurado/DevAssignment-1

What this report includes

- Research of three task apps and three timer/tracking apps; the resulting product choices.
- A short PRD, design and technical decisions, and testable acceptance criteria.
- Three original hand-drawn visual artifacts, each with the decision it helped make.
- Actual FocusDesk Obsidian records, testing evidence, an AI-use note, and reflection.

The original research PDF and sketches are Yuki's work. App screenshots from a disposable test vault are not presented as the student's hand-drawn visuals.

01 / RESEARCH

Research: task applications

The judgments below come from my supplied *App Research–Assignment 1.pdf*. Vendor pages were checked for product descriptions; these notes are not hands-on usability tests.

Application	Useful observation and what I took from it	Left out of FocusDesk
Todoist [1]	A friendly, structured task list suggested clear task cards and easy entry.	Collaboration and multi-user assignment.
Microsoft To Do [2]	Simple lists and list groups suggested keeping organization understandable. Grouping was deferred in v1.	Outlook/Microsoft account integration.
TickTick [3]	Its task-plus-Pomodoro pattern supported combining both functions in one app.	Habit tracking, calendar suite and collaboration.

Research: timer and tracking applications

Application	Useful observation and what I took from it	Left out of FocusDesk
Pomofocus [4]	Custom focus/break timing and visual reports inspired the session flow and day/week/month bars.	Estimated finish time.
Toggl Track [5]	One-click timing and reporting reinforced direct Start/Stop controls and actual-time summaries.	Background auto-tracking and agency reporting.
Clockify [6]	Simple time entry and reporting showed the value of low-friction tracking.	GPS, kiosk, invoicing and team administration.

Ideas selected: a timer attached to each task; a bar chart of actual completed focus time; a small task-colour palette. FocusDesk is intended for one student, so team features and cloud accounts are outside the first version.

Correction to my original research: the earlier “unlimited free users” claim for Clockify is not used as a design fact; current pricing terms can change [7].

02 / PRODUCT

Short product requirements document

Purpose and user. FocusDesk is for a student who needs help choosing work, staying focused, and seeing where study time went. It runs locally without an account, stores state on the computer, and writes task/focus events to a vault selected by the user.

Core features

- Tasks: create, view, edit, delete, complete and reopen. Tasks survive restarting the app.
- Focus: choose a task or enter a short activity description; start, pause, resume, stop/cancel, finish early or complete at zero. Paused time is excluded.
- Breaks: adjustable focus and break lengths; remind the user shortly before focus ends and offer an optional break after completion. Break time is separate from actual focus time.
- History and Stats: completed sessions and day/week/month bars of actual time per task, with description-only sessions under “Other activities.”

Personal features

A task can have an optional description, colour, and suggested focus/break length. A task's Focus action opens its own Timer page. A one-time +5-minute extension is available during focus. These are chosen features, not minimum requirements.

Non-goals

Accounts, cloud sync, collaboration, calendar planning, task groups, automatic background tracking, and billing are outside this version.

Main user flow

- Select an existing Obsidian vault, then create a task on Tasks / Home.
- Click Focus on a task; Timer opens with suggested lengths, which can be adjusted for that session. Alternatively start a description-only activity.
- Complete focus, optionally take a break, then review actual active time on Stats. Mark the task complete separately when the work is truly done.

Acceptance checks

- Tasks and completed sessions persist after restart; all required actions make one appropriate Markdown event in the selected vault.
- Pause and closed-app time do not increase actual duration; cancelled sessions do not enter Stats; breaks do not enter focus totals.
- The app works offline, the README supports a clean clone, and old vault events are never silently overwritten.

03 / IMPLEMENTATION

Design and technical decisions

Decision	Choice and reason
One combined app	Tasks, Timer and Stats are separate pages in one Electron window and one repository. A task can open its focus session directly.
Electron + plain JS	HTML, CSS and JavaScript were already familiar from class; Electron provides desktop file and folder access without a remote service.
Local state	Task, session, setting and pending-event data live in an app-owned JSON file, saved on meaningful changes.
Obsidian records	FocusDesk/tasks and FocusDesk/focus contain one uniquely named Markdown file per event. Records include date, time, timezone, type, status and identifiers. A failed write stays pending for retry.
Three-page layout	Tasks is home; task Focus opens Timer; Stats houses history and the bar chart. Blue surfaces and task-colour accents keep the interface calm and scannable.
Usability	Stop warns about cancellation; Finish saves active time. Optional task suggestions provide a starting value without turning them into an estimate of actual time.
Alternative not chosen	A Vue front end and two separate apps were considered. Plain JavaScript and one app reduce setup and integration work for this assignment.

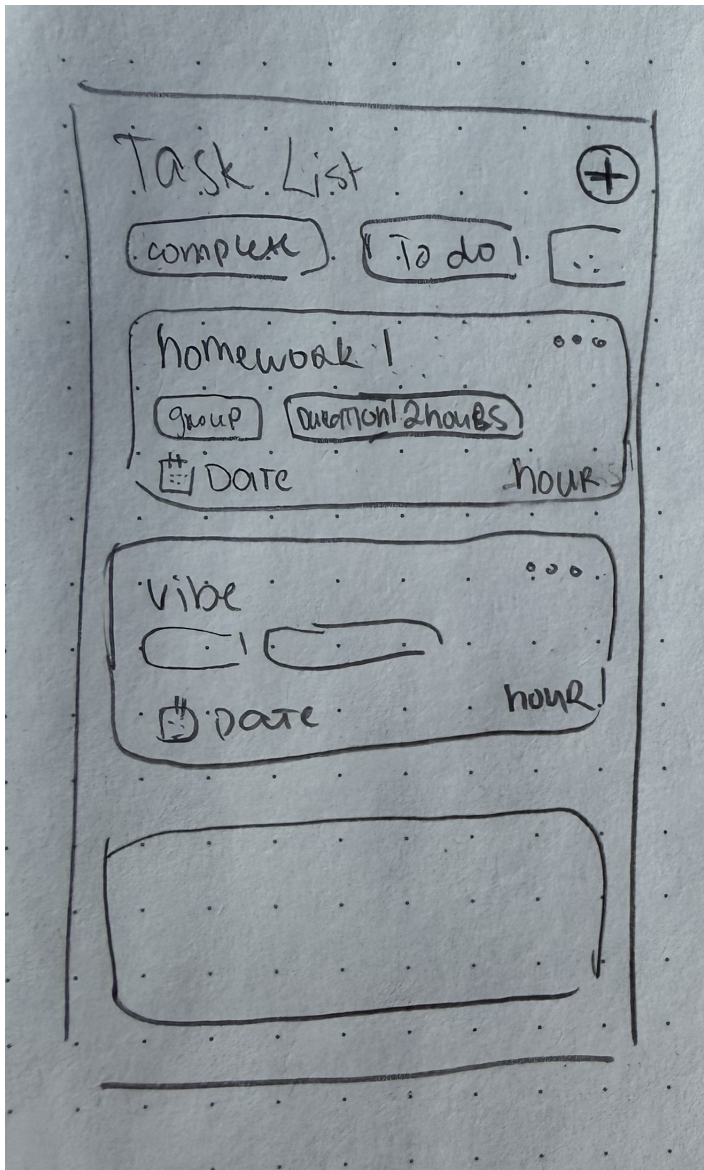
Evidence from implementation

- The app passes 27 automated tests, including three break-notification checks. An earlier clean clone installed dependencies and passed the then-current 24 tests.
- An isolated Electron check used a disposable vault: task creation, task-to-Timer navigation, session overrides, completion, Stats, description-only focus, and a break worked.
- The student previously checked real-vault task and focus events in Obsidian; a final real-vault check of the redesigned app and an offline run remain useful before submission.

These checks show what was exercised; they do not claim every possible timer or operating-system edge case has been manually tested.

04 / VISUAL ARTIFACT 1

Tasks / Home



Original hand-drawn sketch

Yuki's drawing in the project reference folder. It records the early idea rather than a finished app screenshot.

Decision it helped make

The large add action and individual task cards made the task list easy to scan. Each card needed a direct way to begin focusing.

How the final design changed

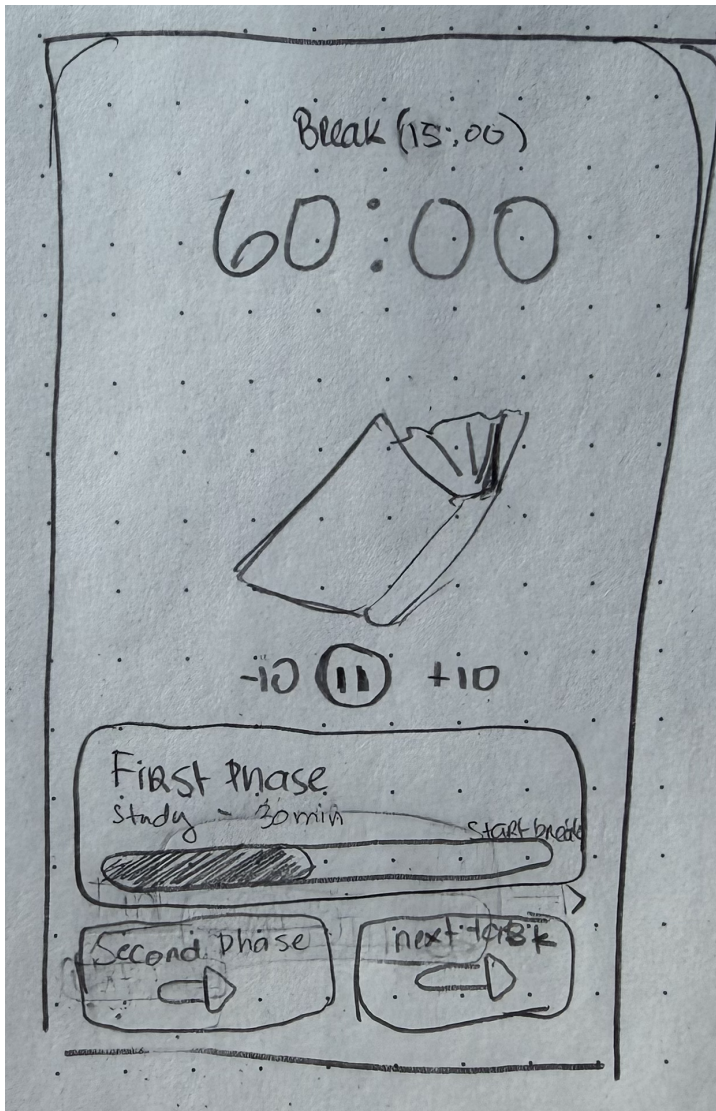
The sketch explored groups, dates and estimated hours. Those were dropped for v1. The implemented page keeps title, optional description, colour, suggested focus/break times and a Focus button.

Result: Tasks became the home page; the blue desktop layout separates adding from reviewing existing tasks.

Artifact 1: Task-List-Sketch.png — original student sketch stored in references/.

04 / VISUAL ARTIFACT 2

Timer and breaks



Original hand-drawn sketch

Yuki's drawing in the project reference folder. It records the early idea rather than a finished app screenshot.

Decision it helped make

A large countdown should be the visual centre. The drawing also suggested obvious pause and break controls.

How the final design changed

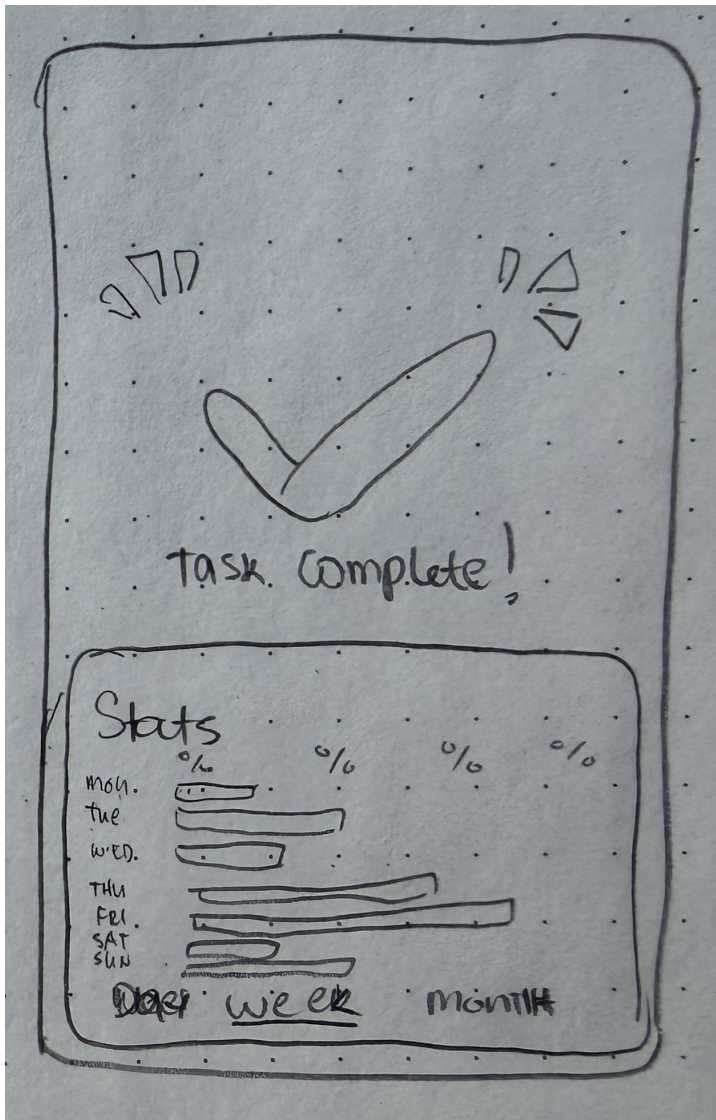
The drawn 60:00 and ± 10 are exploratory values. The built timer uses adjustable lengths, a once-only +5 extension, explicit Pause/Resume/Finish/Stop actions, and an optional break offer.

Result: Clicking a task opens Timer with its suggested lengths; a short activity can also be entered without a task.

Artifact 2: Timer-Sketch.png — original student sketch stored in references/.

04 / VISUAL ARTIFACT 3

Stats and progress



Original hand-drawn sketch

Yuki's drawing in the project reference folder. It records the early idea rather than a finished app screenshot.

Decision it helped make

The sketch raised the idea of a completion message and a bar chart that makes progress visible across days, weeks and months.

How the final design changed

Its percentage bars became bars of **actual completed focus time** per task. Stats is now a separate page with session history and Day/Week/Month filters. Breaks and cancelled sessions are excluded.

Result: the chart answers where study time went rather than claiming a task is a certain percent finished.

Artifact 3: Stats-Sketch.png — original student sketch stored in references/.

05 / EVIDENCE

Actual Obsidian records

These examples are from the student's selected desktop vault and were generated by the running FocusDesk app on 26 September 2026. Each event is a separate Markdown file; the examples below are excerpts, not manually invented events.

Task creation — FocusDesk/tasks/a34f7a7b-27d9-4d52-bb3b-bd5d41f1b8e0.md

```
Event type: task-created
Status: open
Date: 2026-09-26
Time: 16:18:02
Timezone: Europe/Brussels (UTC+02:00)
Task ID: 4e9ac0e7-eb45-4a87-a7ae-899f02c38ce5
Title: Test-Readchapter3
```

Focus completion — FocusDesk/focus/8276ffd5-fe27-461e-bf4e-bb693c7492b1.md

```
Event type: focus-completed
Status: completed
Date: 2026-09-26
Time: 16:46:09
Timezone: Europe/Brussels (UTC+02:00)
Task title: Test-Read Book 3
Planned minutes: 1
Actual active duration: 60000 ms
```

How logging works

- Task events go to FocusDesk/tasks; focus starts, completions and cancellations go to FocusDesk/focus.
- Each file name is a unique event ID. The original files remain unchanged after later edits or status changes.
- The app's Stats chart is calculated from locally saved completed sessions; Obsidian receives event records, not an automatic chart note.

The separate .md sample required for submission should be copied from an actual app-generated vault file. Do not use an isolated test-vault example as that sample.

06 / PROCESS

AI use, reflection and sources

AI note

I used Hermes with separate Coder and Researcher profiles to plan and build FocusDesk. I supplied the initial research, answered product questions, and drew the original sketches. AI helped refine the PRD, write and revise code, test storage/timer/UI behaviour, inspect the Electron app, document decisions, and assemble this report. Codex directly helped implement the local Stats bar chart and review the Obsidian connection. I checked real vault notes and a real countdown myself. The final work, source judgments and submission remain my responsibility. This note summarizes the work; it is not a full chat transcript.

Personal reflection

“The most challenging part was connecting Codex with Hermes and keeping the files together so Obsidian could use them. I learned that Electron can run a local desktop app for a project like this.”

— Yuki Jevelle Jurado

Before final submission

- Run the redesigned app once with the real vault and once without internet; confirm the new task and focus events appear.
- Submit one app-generated .md sample separately using the brief's required filename.

Sources

Student source: *App Research-Assignment 1.pdf* (Yuki Jevelle Jurado). Assignment source: *3IXD_Dev5_Assignment_1.pdf*. Product pages checked 27 September 2026; vendors may change features and pricing.

[1] Todoist — <https://www.todoist.com/features>

[2] Microsoft To Do — <https://support.microsoft.com/en-us/todo/what-s-new-in-microsoft-to-do>

[3] TickTick — <https://ticktick.com/>

[4] Pomofocus — <https://pomofocus.io/>

[5] Toggl Track — <https://toggl.com/>

[6] Clockify — <https://clockify.me/>

[7] Clockify pricing — <https://clockify.me/pricing>